

Political Theory

Chapter 1 : Introduction to Political Theory

Welcome to AnithUncommon's Sample Resources!

This sample will be divided into **three** parts: Introduction to Samples (this part), Lesson Objectives (What is Expected From Students), and most crucially, Syllabus Contents.

Note that the 'Syllabus Content' does NOT stand as a complete syllabus itself; rather, it is a tight compilation of notes gathered by (Mentor Name) to create a comprehensive sample for students.

If you want a complete version of these notes and think that you need help in Political Theory, join our nonprofit!

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— Made by students, for students

Lesson Objectives:

At the end of the lesson, students should be *able* to...

- **Define** Politics and Political Theory in their own words.
- **Explain** why studying Political Theory is important using real-life situations.
- **Express** their understanding by applying theoretical approaches to real-life examples and writing a short written explanation.

Reflective Questions to Consider:

Everyone associates politics to what politicians and political parties do. Sometimes, they say they do not even want to follow it because of these negative views. However, politics is a culmination of historical, ethnic and cultural circumstances of a population or territory. It is largely influenced by a sense of nationalism and collective belonging, and politicians and political parties hence try to reflect these individual circumstances of society in their narratives.

Below is the following core questions you will face as we explore this chapter:

- What is Politics and how do different people define it? Is there a common definition everyone can use?
- If Political Theory is a culmination of historical narratives, then how is it different from History?

Syllabus Outline:

Unit 1 : Introduction to Political Theory	
Tips! • Concepts might feel abstract in some places, and you may face difficulty understanding ideas like “rights” and “constitutional amendments” as they aren’t exactly tangible. ALWAYS connect such concepts to ANY real life examples. Samples can be found in the Mentor’s Notes! • Do not try to memorise content and keywords/ideas without clearly understanding it, as that will be useless. Break ideas down with the help of your mentor and clearly comprehend it before trying to memorise anything. Activities in Class: • Lesson Breakdown • Ethical Dilemma to discuss and debate with your mentor using the socratic method of teaching, “Does society influence Politics or does Politics influence society more?” • Complete a short written reflection and discuss it with your mentor, “Do we really need Political Theory to understand society or can we focus only on real-world experience?”	
Introduction to Political Theory Section 1.1 : What is Politics?	Mentor’s Notes

• You would have noticed that people have different ideas about what Politics is. Political leaders who contest elections and hold political office may argue that it is a kind of “public service”. Some others associate Politics with manipulation and intrigue undertaken to satisfy what one wants. A few relate Politics directly with what politicians do, they may hence relate it directly to scams. Disillusioned by such pursuits, we tend to despair of Politics, and say we want to stay away from it. • No society can exist without some form of Political Organization and collective decision-making. A society that wishes to sustain itself needs to take the needs of multiple members into account. Such institutions help us find ways of living together and acknowledging our obligations to one another despite our differences. • How governments are formed, and how they function is thus the focus of Politics. But politics is not confined to the affairs of government. In fact what governments do is relevant because it affects the lives of the people in many different ways. • It involves the multiple negotiations that go on in society through which collective decisions are made. At one level, it involves what governments do and how they relate to the aspirations of the people; at another level, it involves how people struggle and influence decision making.	Thinkers like Mahatma Gandhi have observed that Politics envelops us like the coils of a snake and there is no other way out but to wrestle with it! Think about this ideology and define what Politics is to you.
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Section 1.2 : What is Political Theory?

- If we look around us, what we see would be movement, development and change. But if we look deeper we would also see **certain values and principles that have inspired people and guided policies, ideals like democracy, freedom or equality for instance**. Different countries may try to **protect such values by promulgating them in their constitutions as is the case of the American and Indian constitutions**.
- These documents did not just emerge overnight; they were **built upon the ideas and principles** debated almost since the time of Kautilya to Aristotle to Jean Jacques Rousseau, Karl Marx, Mahatma Gandhi and Dr. B.R. Ambedkar. As far back as the fifth century B.C., Plato and Aristotle discussed with their students whether monarchy or democracy was better. In modern times, Rousseau first argued for freedom as a fundamental right of humankind. Karl Marx argued that equality was as crucial as freedom. Closer home, Mahatma Gandhi discussed the meaning of genuine freedom or swaraj in his book Hind Swaraj. Dr. Ambedkar vigorously argued that the scheduled castes must be considered a minority.
- **Political theory deals with the ideas and principles that shape Constitutions, governments and social life in a systematic manner**. It clarifies the **meaning of concepts such as freedom, equality, justice, democracy, secularism** and so on. It **probes the significance of**

We see that **governments determine our economic policy and foreign policy and educational policy**. These policies can help to improve the **lives of people but are inefficient or corrupt**. The government can also endanger **people's lives and security**. If the **government in power allows any conflicts to become violent, markets close down and schools are shut**. These disrupt our **lives; we cannot buy things that we may need urgently; those who are sick cannot reach the hospital; even the school schedule gets**

principles such as rule of law, separation of powers, judicial review, etc. This is done by examining the arguments advanced by different thinkers in defence of these concepts. Section 1.3 : What do we study in Political Theory? • Though Rousseau or Marx or Gandhi did not become politicians, yet their ideas influenced generations of politicians everywhere. There are also contemporary thinkers who draw upon them to defend freedom or democracy in our own time. Besides examining arguments, political theorists also reflect upon our current political experiences and point out trends and possibilities for the future. • But is all this relevant for us now? Have we not already achieved freedom and democracy? While most of our world is free and independent, questions regarding freedom and equality have not ceased to crop up. • This is because issues concerning freedom, equality, democracy, arise in many areas of social life and they are being implemented in different sectors at different paces. For instance, although equality may exist in the political sphere in the form of equal rights, it may not exist to the same extent in the economic or social spheres. People may enjoy equal political rights but still be discriminated against socially because of their caste or poverty.	affected, syllabi cannot be completed and we may have to take extra coaching for the exams and pay tuition fees. If, on the other hand, the government makes policies to increase literacy and employment, we may get an opportunity to go to a good school and get a decent job. India has been deeply affected by the caste system. The religion
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- Some people may have a privileged place in society while others are deprived even of basic necessities. Some are able to achieve whatever goals they set for themselves while many are unable even to go to schools so that they can have decent jobs in the future. For them, freedom is still a distant dream. Although freedom is guaranteed, we encounter new interpretations all the time.
- Thirdly, **as our world changes, we may discover new dimensions of freedom as well as new threats to freedom.**
- Political Theory has a lot to do to **provide answers to how much control the government should have over our rights, and how we can protect them.**

Section 1.4 : Why should we study Political Theory?

- We are all going to be citizens entitled to vote and decide other issues. To **act responsibly**, it is **helpful** to have a **basic knowledge** of the **political ideas** and **institutions** that **shape the world** we live in. In the information society, it is **crucial** that we learn to be **reasonable** and **informed** if we are **to participate in elections** in such a way. If we are **simply arbitrary** in our preferences, we will **not be very effective** in expressing our views about political parties. If we have **factual knowledge** about our **rights** to **ground our opinions in**, **no political leader** will be able to **misuse their power**.

Hinduism was divided into various levels or castes, ones who were at the bottom caste were treated like 'untouchables', enforcing one of the most inhumane forms of discrimination where this group of people was not permitted to worship in temples, drink water from the same wells, go to school or take any job other than picking up garbage. Scheduled Castes is derived from the fact that these castes are now 'scheduled' or mentioned in a section under the constitution with special privileges like reservations in universities and jobs

- Freedom, equality and secularism are not abstract issues in our lives.

Section 1.5 : Is Political Theory only about the past, and how does it differ from History?

- Political Theory is not at all related to History, **however it is sometimes necessary to study events of the past to understand how we have evolved as a society** to create solutions to the issues that existed in the past.
- While it also consists of studies of thinkers and past systems, it is **largely focused** on understanding **current issues** such as **inequalities and rights**. It helps us **analyse modern challenges** and **think about possible solutions**. Political Theory focuses on **reasoning behind political decisions**.
- History focuses on events that **actually happened in the past, like timelines and outcomes**. History **explains what happened** and **how**. Political Theory explains **why decisions were made** and **whether** they were **justified** and what kind of **groups or events in the past triggered decisions** and **systems to be enforced**.

to recover them from their past which did not allow them to grow.

This is a bit like playing a game; as we play chess or cricket, we learn how to interpret the rules. In the process, we discover new and broader meanings of the game itself. Similarly, the fundamental rights guaranteed by constitutions across the world are continually being reinterpreted in response to new circumstances and so we need to be aware of how such

	amendments take place to be able to wage legal struggles against these if they deny our rights! Now, think about threats to freedom as well as dimensions of freedom using this context, For instance, global communications technology is making it easier for activists to network with one another across the world for protecting tribal cultures or forests. But it also enables terrorists and criminals to network. Moreover, internet commerce is all set to
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	increase in the future. This means that the information we give about ourselves online to buy goods or services must be protected. The first step towards protecting our rights and creating a sense of security is KNOWING our rights. We ourselves have prejudices against people who are different from us, be they of a different caste or religion or gender or class. If we feel oppressed, we want it redressed and if that is delayed, we feel violent revolution is justified. If we are privileged, we deny that there is any
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	oppression, for example, the upper class sometimes may deny that their servants or maids may suffer any indignation.
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Mentors' Sources:

<https://ncert.nic.in/textbook/pdf/keps1ps.pdf>

<https://ncert.nic.in/textbook.php?keps1=1-8>

<https://www.epw.in/>

